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20 Questions and a Motive for Murder

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20 Questions and a Motive for Murder

By Stephanie Christensen

Priscilla: Welcome to the mansion of Professor Singh. My name is Priscilla and might I say, the full moon lights up the garden in a rather ghastly way this evening. Aaaand you all look deliciously hungry! Gather round, dear dinner guests, but not too close, or you might uncover a dish you do not like.

Gibby: (raises hand) I've never met a dish I didn't like!

Priscilla: Clearly, you chunky monkey! I mean, revered guest.

Angel: Ummmmm… can I just say this is really weird? I thought this was an end-of-semester dinner hosted by Professor Singh. Who invited all of these (motions to audience) creepers here? Why are they watching us so closely?

Frankie (eccentric, egotistical, hippie): They came for me… I'm dinner AND the show!

Diego: (looks at Frankie with flirtatious smile) Dinner indeed… you'se several snacks, girl. I can never keep my eyes off you in class. You too, Angel!

Angel: EW.

Priscilla: Enough! You college students drone on and on with your incessant complaints. Who are you, Priscilla? What are we doing here? "I feel unsafe." POPPYCOCK.

Gibby (scared): I think I might leave now.

Priscilla: Not without your meal, you won't. Have you ever left without eating a meal?

Angel: Stop with the over-eating jokes. Am I making jokes about your nasty face mole and forehead wrinkles? (sassy, unapologetic) Ooh. I guess I just did.

Gibby: YEAH! Am I making jokes about (points to audience member) that person's gnarly hair? Really, dude… heard of a shower?

Frankie (spiritual): All locks are sacred locks! (turns to audience member) NEVER cut your hair, okay? NEVER CUT YOUR SACRED HAIR.

Diego: Yo, look, it's Professor Singh!

Professor Singh: Hello, children. Welcome to my home and congratulations on your exemplary grades this semester. Gibby, an A- and awful final paper. Angel, a B minus, how awkwardly predictable. Diego, with the consistent C plus. And, of course, an F for Frankie.

Frankie: F for Frankie, or F for freakin' awesome?

Priscilla: F for failure at life.

Professor Singh: You have each fallen under a unique subcategory of failure in my class.

Gibby: Whoa, whoa, whoa, I got an A!

Angel: And I got a B! Plus, I don't think you're supposed to say all of our grades out loud in front of each other, Professor. That's kind of messy.

Frankie: Bad vibes, dude… you've got institutional university sellout written all over your face.

Gibby: Yeah, and if this is a celebration dinner, why am I the only one here with an actual good grade?

Diego (gives Gibby an offended look): Hey?!?

Professor Singh: Oh Gibby. You still think an A- is good? (motions to an audience member) Ask that overachiever "try-hard" in the audience if they think an A- is good. (asks audience member) Do you? Do your parents think an A- is good? Does it keep you up at night?!?

Angel: Whoa, professor, I think you need to chill on harassing the bystanders.

Priscilla: SILLY CHILD, the strangers in the audience are not bystanders! They are here to join the dinner party and be punished as well.

Frankie: (gasps in excitement) Well, WELCOME, friends!

Gibby: (gulps) Did you say punished?

Diego (turns to an audience member, raises eyebrows): Dawg, I think she said we're being punished… I'm not sticking around that.

Professor Singh: Yes, Gibby and Diego, punished. This is a tradition of mine every semester… tonight, you, my loser students, will sit for dinner and a game of 20 questions. It will be a lovely evening of torture!

Angel: Somebody needs to call University and report this.

Professor Singh: Priscilla, will you please seat our guests and introduce them to the game, while that (points dramatically) audience member brings out the first course?

Priscilla: Why of course, my liege!

Diego: Man, I want a servant at my beck and call like that. It would be nice if it were a pretty girl though, not miss wrinkly mc-mole pants.

Angel: (sarcastic) One day, some woman is going to be so lucky to have you.

Diego: Hey, Frankie loves it when I flirt with her.

Frankie: well, frankly, I find peace and connection with all living creatures.

Diego: (indignant) But she likes me the most.

Priscilla: Stop the incessant whining! Now, while you all enjoy this appetizing soup starter…

Angel: (opening dish cover) Is this Cup of Noodles?

Priscilla: We will be starting our little game. One of you have been specially selected as Professor Singh's least favorite student, and tonight, using the game of 20 questions, we will find out exactly who that is.

Gibby: Oh, MAN. This social setting is literally my worst nightmare.

Priscilla: So, how about we start with Diego? You must ask a "yes" or "no" question, and the goal is to make Professor Singh to give you an identifying description of the FAILURE he has in mind.

Diego: Uhhh alright… is it a guy or a girl?

Angel: That is not a yes or no question, Diego.

Diego: Yes it is… either he says, "yes, it's a guy" or "no, it's a girl."

Angel: We're never going home.

Professor Singh: Diego, you've lost your turn. Question number two is for Frankie.

Frankie: Hmmm… does this person have a spiritual connection with you?

Professor Singh: No. Question 3 for Angel.

Angel: That didn't narrow us down at all, Frankie. Is this person a girl?

Professor Singh: Yes.

Priscilla: (to the audience) Now you gasp, audience.

Angel: YES?! That narrows it down to two of us!

Professor Singh: Well, looks like someone is smart after all. Question 4 for Gibby.

Gibby: Uh… uh… (wiping sweat from forehead and armpits). I'm sorry about this. I sweat profusely when I'm nervous.

Angel: You're not even on the chopping block anymore!

Gibby: I know, but all of these people are watching me! Oh, shoot! I just dropped some sweat into my soup. Can I get another one?

Professor Singh: Gibby, you've lost your turn. Question 5, Diego.

Diego: Uh… Is she hot?

Frankie: (flattered, clutches chest) Thank you! (blows kiss at Diego)

Professor Singh: Disgustingly inappropriate. No. Question 6.

Frankie: (gives him a look) rude!

Angel: it's your turn, Frankie… can we just wrap this up?

Frankie: Was this person in your class, Professor Singh?

(Professor Singh stares at her deadpan) (Frankie stares back innocently, blinks inquisitively)

Professor Singh: (looking at her like she is crazy, speaks slowly) Yes. You. All. Were.

Priscilla: Alriiiiigghhht, I think we've had enough of round one! We have 14 questions left and are making very embarrassing progress, considering how easy this game is with four people.

Angel: (to audience) Do any of you have a car? I want to get out of here but I carpooled with Gibby, and he looks too impaired to drive.

Gibby (making nervous noises, wiping sweat off self): Uggghhh this is awful, this is awful… can I have more napkins?

Priscilla: Please prepare yourselves for the main course. Angel, since you seem to have a problem with the game, will you come join me in the kitchen to prepare the entrée?

Angel: Ah yes, I would love to help the waitstaff. My self-esteem wasn't low enough already.

Gibby: Uh, while they're doing that, can we continue the game, Professor Singh? (eyes track them walking into the kitchen, he turns to whisper to the audience) I'm 99.99% positive that

Frankie is his least favorite student. She was the one who got an F, and she almost never comprehends what we are saying.

Frankie (spiritual, zoned off): What was that, Gibby? I was tuning out.

Professor Singh: That is an classically predictable guess, Gibby. Would you like to lock it in as your final answer? Audience, what do you think? Lock it in?

Diego: Lock it in! Lock it in! Lock it in!

Gibby: (nervous, sweating) UHHHH… Uh… I don't know! Now I'm nervous. I want to be sure… but let's do it. Let's lock it in!

Professor Singh: WRONG. You had a 50/50 shot, and just as I should've known, you absolutely butchered it. You failure students are so predictable with your butchering.

Angel (screams, running in from the kitchen): AHHHH! HELP ME, HELP ME! SHE'S TRYING TO BUTCHER ME!

Priscilla (holding a butcher knife over her head): STAND STILL, ANGEL! YOU ARE THE MAIN COURSE TONIGHT.

Diego: Whoa whoa whoa, get behind me Angel! And you put down the knife, crazy lady!

Frankie: Stand back! Your negative energy is palpable in the air!

Gibby: WHAT THE GIBLETS IS GOING ON?

Professor Singh: Oh students… Angel is my least favorite, it is true. And that, Angel, is because you have had so much potential for improvement. You got a B minus in my class, but you have a brilliant, intuitive mind. You are just wasting it on other ventures.

Angel: Your class SUCKED, Professor Singh! You made us do pre-homework before our homework and stay late after school to practice our public speaking! Like literal torture, every day of the week! (motions to audience) these people relate!

Professor Singh: And you still managed to embarrass me. To pay for your lack of motivation, you will become an example. This might seem scary now, but one simple murder, and the rest of these fools will surely try harder in their next endeavors.

Gibby: Uhhh I'm pretty sure I'll just pee myself.

Frankie: Me too.

Diego: Too late for me.

Angel: Diego, really? I'm right *behind* you!

Priscilla: Come on, silly girl, give in to your fate now! You can't come to a big dinner party full of murderous strangers at a murderous mansion, and not expect us to have a motive for murder.

Angel: (looking desperately at the audience) Ah, come on, these strangers can't be that bad. They don't want to see me murdered, right? Right?!

Frankie: No offense, Angel, but they kind of look like they do.

Priscilla: They came for a hilarious show, after all! And that they will get!

Diego (runs up to audience member): Listen, listen. They said we're all going to be punished, right? You're going to be punished, we're going to be punished. So we can't let them kill Angel! We have to do something!

Gibby (also speaking to audience): I've got a plan. Follow my lead. Frankie is going to start chanting a spell to distract Professor Singh, while we all distract that Priscilla witch. Look, Frankie is starting now!

Frankie (spiritually humming and moving arms up and down): Ooh chaka- laka, ooh chaka-laka! I enchant you! I enchant you! Red leather, yellow leather. Red leather, yellow leather. Listen to my spirit song! Ohmmm!!!

Professor Singh: Get your malodourous armpits out of my face, Frankie.

Gibby (to audience): Great, now it's our job. I'll yell red leather at Priscilla, and you yell yellow leather. RED LEATHER! (waits for response, proceed with chant after pausing whether or not audience responds or not). RED LEATHER! (pause again). RED LEATHER!

Priscilla (looking back in forth with confusion between Gibby and audience, swiveling around to point butcher knife and both Gibby and the audience): What—what are you doing? What are you saying? There's no such thing as red leather!

Angel: Alright crazy lady, you're about to be struck by an angel! AHHHHH!! (Angel throws a punch)

Priscilla: (falls backwards and drops knife) Oh no, I dropped the knife! And you've hurt my face!

Angel (throws a second punch): Take this!

Diego: WHOA! K.O.! You knocked her out, Angel!

Gibby (to audience, either sarcastic if they did not participate or enthusiastic if they did): GREAT JOB! You guys did an awesome job of saying yellow leather. It's like you had training in it or something.

Frankie: Alright everyone, let's make our great escape to freedom! F is for freedom, not failure! It's time we get out of here and report Professor Creep to the police!

Professor Singh (begging): No, please don't! I'll be fired!

Angel: That's really the most of your worries after attempted murder? Come on, everyone! (to audience) Creepy bystanders, it's time we get out of here! Don't mind if I throw one last punch first…

Professor Singh (looks at Angel, gulps): Please no—

Angel: You'll wake up to the police, Professor Singh.

Frankie: Radical teamwork, everyone! Seems like we all earned an A tonight.

The End!